FITLER MBA · SESSION 11 SUPPLEMENT

Real Deck Teardown: Airbnb's Seed Pitch

The Sequoia structure, applied to a deck that raised Sequoia's money

A slide-by-slide read of Airbnb's 14-slide seed deck against the Sequoia+ structure and the 7 tests from Session 11, plus the investor's view from Reid Hoffman's annotated LinkedIn deck.

FOLLOW ALONG

Open the deck in a second window: Airbnb's seed pitch deck on Alexander Jarvis's site. The slides run in the same order as the analysis.

SCOTT SILL · OCTOBER 2026

OVERVIEW

Why This Deck

Airbnb's 14-slide seed deck raised $600K, led by Sequoia Capital, in April 2009. It follows almost exactly the Sequoia+ structure from Session 11.

That's no coincidence: it's the Sequoia structure, and it got Sequoia's money. It also does three things we spent the night on:

- It passes most of the 7 tests on the first read.
- Its market slide is a literal TAM / SAM / SOM, built from trips, not dollars.
- Its ask ties the money to one milestone: 80,000 transactions in 12 months.

It isn't perfect, and the gaps teach as much as the strengths. Read it next to the S11 slides, with the 7 tests in mind.

MAP

The Deck at a Glance

Twelve of Airbnb's 14 slides map straight onto Sequoia+. The two extras, press and testimonials, are Traction in disguise.

#	Airbnb slide	Sequoia+ section	Tests it helps pass
1	Title: "Book rooms with locals, rather than hotels"	Purpose	7 Next meeting
2	Problem	Problem	1 Product, 2 Market
3	Solution	Solution	1 Product
4	Market validation	Why now / Traction	2 Market
5	Market size	Market	2 Market
6	Product	Product	1 Product
7	Business model	Business model	4 Ops plan, 5 Fin plan
8	Adoption strategy	Business model (go-to-market)	4 Ops plan
9	Competition	Competition	2 Market, 4 Ops plan
10	Competitive advantages	Competition	2 Market, 4 Ops plan
11	Team	Team	3 Team
12	Press	Traction	3 Team, 4 Ops plan
13	User testimonials	Traction	1 Product, 3 Team
14	Financial	Financials + The Ask	5 Fin plan, 6 Return, 7 Next meeting

The order is classic seed-stage: problem and product first, proof late. With little traction to show, Airbnb led with the idea and the market.

ANALYSIS

Slide-by-Slide Analysis

The deck's strength is plain language and one idea per slide. Its weakness is thin proof, which is normal for a seed deck.

PURPOSE

1 Title

"Book rooms with locals, rather than hotels." Seven words that work as an elevator pitch. It names the customer, the alternative and the difference.

- **Works:** you know the business before slide 2.
- **Lesson:** this is Sequoia's Purpose slide. Write yours in one sentence.

PROBLEM

2 Problem

Three short lines: price matters when booking travel online, hotels cut you off from the city and its culture, and there's no easy way to book a room with a local or become a host.

- **Works:** three problems, one per line, no jargon.
- **Thin:** no proof of the pain. No survey, no cost comparison, no customer story.

SOLUTION

3 Solution

A web platform where people rent out their space to travelers. Three benefits in capitals: SAVE MONEY when traveling, MAKE MONEY when hosting, SHARE CULTURE.

- **Works:** it answers the problem slide point for point, and it speaks to both sides of the marketplace.
- **Lesson:** benefits, not features. "Save money" beats "browse thousands of listings."

WHY NOW / TRACTION

4 Market Validation

Demand already exists: hundreds of thousands of Couchsurfing users and thousands of temporary housing listings a week on Craigslist in San Francisco and New York.

- **Works:** borrowed proof. Airbnb had little traction of its own, so it pointed at people already doing the behavior.
- **Lesson:** if you can't show your own customers, show the customers you'll take.

MARKET

5 Market Size

A TAM / SAM / SOM built from trips: 2 billion trips booked worldwide, 560 million budget and online trips, and 84 million trips Airbnb could capture, 15% of the serviceable market.

- **Works:** it narrows in steps, and sources sit under each number.
- **Thin:** 15% of the SAM is a big capture claim for a seed company. Today an investor would push hard on it.

PRODUCT

6 Product

Three screenshots: search by city, review listings, book it.

- **Works:** you see the whole user flow in three steps. No feature list.

BUSINESS MODEL

7 Business Model

"We take a 10% commission on each transaction." Then the math: 84 million trips × $25 average fee = $2.1 billion in revenue.

- **Works:** one sentence explains how they make money, and the math is on the slide.
- **Thin:** it multiplies the SOM straight into revenue, with no ramp and no costs.

BUSINESS MODEL · GO-TO-MARKET

8 Adoption Strategy

Three channels: events (big festivals and conventions where hotels sell out), partnerships with travel sites, and dual posting to Craigslist.

- **Works:** specific channels, not "social media and word of mouth." Dual posting to Craigslist became a famous growth tactic.
- **Lesson:** name the channel, the way the gates slide named Sales Channel Capacity.

COMPETITION

9 Competition

A 2×2: affordable vs. expensive, offline vs. online. Couchsurfing and Craigslist sit in affordable and offline, Hotels.com and Orbitz in online and expensive, and Airbnb alone in affordable and online.

- **Works:** real named competitors, and a clear empty spot that Airbnb fills.
- **Lesson:** never say "no competition." Draw the map and show your spot.

COMPETITION

10 Competitive Advantages

Six short items, including first to market, ease of use, "list once," and an incentive for hosts that free alternatives can't match.

- **Thin:** several are features, not lasting advantages. First to market rarely holds on its own (S10's McGrath point).

TEAM

11 Team

The three founders, Brian Chesky, Joe Gebbia and Nathan Blecharczyk, with roles, plus an adviser, Michael Seibel of Justin.tv.

- **Works:** design, business and engineering covered, plus a credible adviser.
- **Thin:** it says who they are, not why they win. That's the "why you" question.

TRACTION

12–13 Press and User Testimonials

Press quotes and customer quotes.

- **Works:** third-party proof when you have no revenue yet.
- **Lesson:** this is Traction for a company with almost none. Use what you have.

FINANCIALS + THE ASK

14 Financial

A $500K round for 12 months of runway, to reach 80,000 transactions. At a $25 average fee, that's $2 million in revenue.

- **Works:** the money is tied to one milestone with the math shown. That's the Éclat ask from S11, in real life.
- **Note:** the round closed at $600K, led by Sequoia.

VERDICT

The 7 Tests Scorecard

The deck clearly passes 4 of the 7 tests, partly passes 2, and leaves one mostly to the meeting.

Test	Verdict	Why
1 · I understand the product	**Passed**	Title, solution and the three-step product make it obvious in under a minute
2 · There's a market and an opportunity	**Passed**	Validation plus a stepped TAM / SAM / SOM with sources
3 · I like and trust the team	**Partly**	Right mix of skills and a credible adviser, but no "why us"
4 · I buy the operating plan	**Passed**	Named channels, a competition map, a clear spot to win
5 · I buy the financial plan	**Partly**	The fee math is clear, but there's no ramp, no costs and no path to profit
6 · I can make money investing	**Left to the meeting**	A huge revenue ceiling is implied; the return case isn't made
7 · I want to learn more	**Passed**	Simple, visual, short: it gets the next meeting

Test 6 being left to the meeting is normal at seed. Sequoia was betting on the team and the market, not the model.

PRESSURE TEST

What a 2026 Investor Would Push On

The same deck pitched today would get a second meeting, and a harder one. Expect these questions:

1. **"Why 15%?"** The SOM claims 15% of the serviceable market. Bottom-up, how many bookings can you actually get in year one? That's the gates slide from S11.
2. **"What's the binding gate?"** For Airbnb it was supply: enough hosts in each city. The deck doesn't say how it gets them.
3. **"What does a customer cost?"** No CAC, no conversion rate, no repeat rate. Today these come before revenue projections.
4. **"Why now?"** There's no slide on it. The 2008 downturn, with people needing extra income, was a strong answer that went unused.
5. **"Why you?"** The team slide lists roles. It doesn't say why these three will win.
6. **"What about trust and safety?"** Strangers sleeping in strangers' homes is the obvious objection. Hoffman's lesson, on the next page: answer the biggest objection head-on.

THE INVESTOR'S SIDE

Reid Hoffman's LinkedIn Deck

In 2004 Reid Hoffman pitched LinkedIn's Series B to Greylock Partners. Years later he published the deck with his own notes on each slide.

READ IT

LinkedIn's Series B pitch to Greylock, with Hoffman's commentary. The best public explanation of why a deck is built the way it is.

Read it for five lessons:

- **Lead with the thesis.** Tell investors what you believe first, then show the evidence.
- **Answer the biggest objection early.** In 2004 that was "how does a free network make money," so revenue came near the front.
- **Pitch by analogy, but don't reason by analogy.** He used eBay, PayPal and Google to explain the model, not to prove it.
- **Be contrarian and right.** The best bets look wrong to most people at the time.
- **Show promises kept.** He recapped what the Series A promised and what it delivered, which is Traction for a later round.

Airbnb shows what a strong seed deck looks like. Hoffman shows how a founder thinks while building one. Fast Company's write-up of the deck adds background.

APPLY IT

Lessons for Your Own Deck

Copy Airbnb's clarity, then fix its gaps

1. **One sentence up front.** Your elevator pitch is your title slide.
2. **Benefits, not features.** "Save money" beats a feature list.
3. **Borrow proof if you lack your own.** Show the behavior already happening.
4. **Size the market bottom-up.** Then name the gate that limits you.
5. **Name real competitors.** Draw the map, show your spot.
6. **Answer "why you."** Not just roles: why this team wins.
7. **Tie the money to a milestone.** One number, one outcome, the math shown.

For services businesses

Almost no services firms publish their decks, so there's no ready-made example. Translate instead:

- **Product** becomes how an engagement works, step by step.
- **Market validation** becomes clients already paying someone to solve this.
- **The binding gate** is usually your team's capacity, not demand.
- **The money** often fits a bank line, equipment loan or revenue share better than VC, as in the Éclat example from S11.

REFERENCES

Sources

Slide content comes from published copies of the deck. Secondary sources differ slightly on the validation figures, so this document keeps those approximate.

- Airbnb seed pitch deck, Alexander Jarvis (round details: $600K seed, April 2009, led by Sequoia)
- Airbnb pitch deck example, Upmetrics
- LinkedIn's Series B pitch to Greylock, Reid Hoffman
- Reid Hoffman's 2004 LinkedIn pitch deck, Fast Company, March 2023